

How to Read Your Audiogram

Category: Understand Your Hearing

Best for: Adults reviewing hearing test results, newly diagnosed adults, family members

Evidence level: Professional, public health, clinical audiology sources

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Why your audiogram matters

An audiogram is a graph that shows how well you hear different sounds. It is one of the main tools audiologists use to understand your hearing. Your audiogram can help show whether you have hearing loss, how much hearing loss you have, which pitches are easier or harder to hear, whether one ear hears better than the other, and whether hearing aids or other support may help.

An audiogram does not explain everything about your hearing, but it gives your audiologist an important starting point. It helps connect your test results to your real-life listening difficulties.

The two main parts of the audiogram

An audiogram has two main parts: pitch, also called frequency, and loudness, also called intensity.

Pitch: low sounds to high sounds

Pitch is measured in hertz, often written as Hz. Low-pitched sounds are on the left side of the audiogram. High-pitched sounds are on the right side. Many adults with hearing loss have more difficulty hearing high-pitched sounds. This can make speech sound unclear because many speech clarity sounds are high-pitched and soft.

You may hear that someone is talking, but miss the difference between words like "see" and "she," "cat" and "cap," "fifteen" and "fifty," or "sat" and "fat." This is one reason people with hearing loss often say, "I can hear, but I cannot understand."

Loudness: soft sounds to loud sounds

Loudness is measured in decibels, often written as dB. The top of the audiogram shows very soft sounds. As you move down the graph, sounds become louder. Better hearing is closer to the top.

Your marks on the audiogram show the softest sounds you could hear at each pitch. These marks are called hearing thresholds.

What do the symbols mean?

Audiograms use different symbols to show how each ear hears. Common symbols include O for the right ear and X for the left ear. Other symbols may show bone-conduction results, masked results, or no-response results.

Air conduction and bone conduction

Air-conduction testing is usually done with headphones or earphones. It measures how sound travels through the outer ear, middle ear, inner ear, and hearing nerve pathway.

Bone-conduction testing uses a small device placed behind the ear or on the forehead. It sends sound vibrations through the bone directly to the inner ear. If air-conduction results are worse than bone-conduction results, this may suggest that sound is having trouble traveling through the outer or middle ear. Your audiologist may call this an air-bone gap.

What type of hearing loss do I have?

Conductive hearing loss happens when sound has trouble moving through the outer ear or middle ear.

Sensorineural hearing loss happens when there are changes or damage in the inner ear or hearing nerve pathway.

Mixed hearing loss means there is both a conductive part and a sensorineural part.

How much hearing loss do I have?

Audiologists describe hearing loss by degree. General categories may include normal hearing, slight hearing loss, mild hearing loss, moderate hearing loss, moderately severe hearing loss, severe hearing loss, and profound hearing loss. These categories are based on how loud sounds need to be before you hear them.

What is word recognition?

Word recognition testing helps your audiologist understand how clearly your hearing system processes speech when words are loud enough for you to hear. Two people can have similar audiograms but different speech understanding.

Why your audiogram does not show everything

An audiogram is usually measured in a quiet test room using simple tones. Real life is more complicated. You may need to hear speech in background noise, fast talkers, soft voices, multiple speakers, accents, children's voices, speech from another room, phone calls, TV dialogue, or public announcements.

Your audiogram is one piece of the full picture.

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